

responsible for the audience but I am also scared of them.”

M.S. Subbulakshmi

Singer 1916-2004

ENDLESS ECHO

Waking up to her voice in the morning reciting religious hymns is a deeply personal experience shared by millions. No one has done more to take ordinary people closer to God every single day.

■ By Lakshmi Vishwanathan

In 1947, Mahatma Gandhi famously said he would rather listen to M.S. Subbulakshmi recite the Meera bhajan *Hari thum haro*, than hear it sung by anyone else. Today, we might wonder at the profundity of that wish as Gandhi was no great connoisseur of music. What we do know is that he was a very devout man. He said of Subbulakshmi's music: "Her voice is exceedingly sweet. She loses herself in the bhajan. During prayer one must lose oneself to God. To sing a bhajan is one thing; to sing it by losing oneself to God is quite different." That encapsulates the essence of her music.

Subbulakshmi's life began modestly in the Tamil temple town of Madurai in 1916. Her mother Veena Shanmukavadivu was a musician and mentored her in her early life. Subbulakshmi followed a predestined path as a child artiste, in keeping with the tradition of her family. The world of music sat up to hear her voice when the 16-year-old stormed the male bastion of the Music Academy in Madras, proving her musical credentials in the midst of the stalwarts of the day.

Cinema propelled her to new heights, for her gorgeous voice was now paired with her exquisite features. After her second film came her marriage to T. Sadasivam, a journalist and music buff. The singer had found a mentor she trusted and whose opinion she valued. He was a

worldly man who had significant contacts around the country and helped chart the course of her career. Acting as princess-turned-saint Meera in a film produced by him, Subbulakshmi established herself as an icon of both popular and genteel culture. Thereafter, she did not act in films, but concentrated on her music and reached out to a pan-Indian audience.

Helped by senior statesman C. Rajagopalachari, Subbulakshmi and Sadasivam were at the centre of a cultural renaissance in the country. She sang widely for charity, and won the hearts of grateful admirers. Among them was Jawaharlal Nehru who remarked at a fund-raising concert by Subbulakshmi, "Who am I, but a mere prime minister, to speak in the presence of the queen of music?"

She mastered the songs of great composers, made them her own, and took the level of music appreciation to new heights. From the Padma Bhushan in 1954 to the Bharat Ratna in 1998, there were very few awards that were not bestowed on Subbulakshmi. She was the first woman to be honoured with the title Sangita Kalanidhi, considered the Nobel of Carnatic music, by the Music Academy in 1968. For taking the spiritual message of music to the masses, she received international recognition and was presented with the Ramon Magsaysay award in 1974.

Subbulakshmi's most unique contribution is her series of recordings of purely spiritual verses and chants. Her recordings of the

Venkatesa Suprabhatam, *Bhajagovindam* of saint Adi Sankara, and *Vishnu Sahasranamam* were inspirational, mirroring the intensely personal aspirations of a vast multitude. Today, they continue to resonate in temples and homes, giving her voice a permanent place in the lives of ordinary people.

I grew up listening to her gramophone records and attending her concerts in Mylapore in Chennai. The affection she felt for my mother was reflected in her attitude towards me. It was a life-long bond, strengthened by the unspoken word.

She had style and was always elegantly attired in hand-woven silk sarees with jasmine flowers adorning her hair and diamond nose-rings that matched the glint in her eyes. She epitomised the traditional Indian woman but her modesty veiled a determination to excel in her chosen art. Her life was her music. She knew it and touched the hearts of many with the magic of her unique voice.

I was fortunate to have been embraced by the love of such a great personality. That delicate touch sweetened by just a knowing smile that spoke volumes characterised Subbulakshmi's display of personal affection for me. The memory of those encounters will linger forever, as it, perhaps, will for the many others who have experienced it.

The author has written Subbulakshmi's biography Kunjamma: Ode to a Nightingale